



**Autism
Education
Trust**

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**Department
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School Exclusions

School stress and anxiety - How it can lead to emotional based school avoidance and impact on family life



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Introduction

Autistic pupils can find navigating the social world of school confusing and stressful.

Although they may appear to be coping at school, autistic young people can experience high levels of stress and anxiety. Often their emotions remain bottled up until the end of the school day and released when they are at home, as here they feel fully loved and accepted. Families can see different behaviour at home to that at school and this can be distressing and even endanger families.

If the triggers for this behaviour are not identified and addressed at school, it can lead to emotional based school avoidance and mental health needs.

Here, we look at school life, and how that can impact on autistic young people's differences and behaviours. We also talk about some common reasons for increased stress and anxiety together with strategies to overcome barriers to inclusion.



Introduction

All autistic pupils have differences in:

- **Communication**
Differences in understanding and expressing [communication](#) and language, with skills ranging from individuals who are highly articulate (but may lack understanding) to others who may be non-verbal.
- **Social understanding**
Differences in understanding social behaviour and the feelings of others, which informs the development of friendships and relationships.
- **Sensory processing**
Differences in perceiving [sensory information](#). Hypo (low sensitivity), hyper (high sensitivity) to touch, sight, hearing, smell, taste, vestibular inner ear (balance), proprioceptive (body awareness).
- **Interests and information processing**
Differences in perception, planning, understanding concepts, generalising, predicting, managing transitions, passions for interests and ability to absorb auditory or spoken information.



How school life impacts on an autistic pupil's differences and behaviour

It is vital to understand why a pupil may be behaving in a way that is causing concern. By doing this you can make reasonable adjustments and provide the appropriate support to reduce or replace that behaviour and avoid emotional based school avoidance. This can also help families who see [different behaviour at home to that seen in school](#).

There is no 'one size fits all' approach when working with autistic young people. Each person is an individual and the same [behaviour](#) may have different causes or functions. It is important to interpret a pupil's actions from their perspective.



Common reasons for increased stress and anxiety

- Transitions between lessons (noisy, crowded corridors).
- [Unstructured times of day](#) (break, lunchtimes).
- [Sensory](#) overload and/or fear of specific sounds.
- Working cooperatively in groups or team games in PE.
- Misunderstanding sarcasm, 'banter', 'dares'.
- Social issues – friendships, bullying, teasing, love, emotion.
- Lack of personal space.
- Unexpected [change](#) to the timetable.
- Coping with the curriculum and striving for perfection.
- Being away from the familiar routines, family and home.
- Disliking a particular member of staff or subject.
- [Differences processing](#) instructions and misunderstanding what is required.



Strategies to overcome barriers to inclusion

Individual pupil

- Listen to what an autistic pupil thinks about their experiences at school. Ask how their day has been, but give closed options to avoid an ambiguous 'OK'.
- Have a home/school communication book.
- Use a behaviour diary to identify if there is a pattern to absences from school and incidents at home. Is the pupil trying to avoid a particular situation, lesson or person that causes them anxiety?
- Use visual stress scales – for example, a stress thermometer, or a traffic light system to help pupils regulate their emotions.
- Ask the pupil to determine the severity of [bullying](#) incidents using a visual scale, with incidents rated 1-10 according to their severity. Report those above an agreed point in line with the school's anti-bullying policy.
- Think about the impact of any co-occurring conditions and differences that the pupil may have – for example, learning differences, epilepsy, Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD), visual or hearing impairments or problems with mental health.
- Consider that they may also have disturbed [sleep](#) patterns and problems with [eating](#), keeping hydrated and [toileting](#) routines, which can significantly affect their wellbeing.
- Work with the pupil to identify strategies which will help to reduce stress.
- Make reasonable adjustments at the end of the school day, such as allowing time for the pupil to engage in their own special interest activity or letting them leave before other pupils, if necessary.



Strategies to overcome barriers to inclusion

Building relationships

- Arrange for a member of staff with whom the autistic pupil has a good relationship to meet them at the school gate, their parent's car or from other transport.
- Build a good relationship with the pupil to support their learning and sense of wellbeing. However, avoid over dependence on one member of staff.
- Support autistic pupils to build relationships with peers.
- Work with families to develop a morning and after school routine (encourage use of [visual schedules](#), down time after school and strategies to relieve stress – for example, exercise, trampoline or punch bag).
- Work with other professionals, including education welfare. Ensure that they are all aware of the impact that the confines of school have on the pupil and how that can cause anxiety and stress to them and their family.
- Organise [autism awareness training](#) for all staff, including lunch time supervisors.
- Use personal, social, health and economic education (PSHE) lessons and assemblies to teach all pupils about accepting diversity and difference, including disabilities. A general assembly to teach autism awareness may avoid a particular pupil feeling uncomfortable.
- Ask parents what their priorities are for their child. You can use the AET parents' guide: [Working together with your child's school](#).

Enabling environments

You should identify any [sensory differences](#) an autistic pupil may have and consider how the physical and sensory environment will impact on their learning.

With this in mind, you could:

- Identify a quiet and safe place that the pupil can use, giving them an exit or time-out card so that they can access this whenever they feel overwhelmed.
- Provide a suitable work space in the classroom.
- Identify which aspects of the school day or physical environment are causing anxiety.
- Use a plan of the school and encourage the pupil to colour code areas where they need additional support.
- Look at ways in which the communication style of school staff might be changed to make it easier for the autistic pupil to understand and learn.



Strategies to overcome barriers to inclusion

Curriculum and learning

- Consider a short-term, part-time timetable to avoid emotional based school avoidance, or to support an autistic pupil who is returning to school after an absence.
- Encourage the pupil to give a mark out of ten for each lesson. For those lessons they score low, ask them why.
- Use interests to differentiate work so that it motivates the pupil. Consider making the curriculum meaningful and relevant to the pupil, addressing their aspirations and career options.
- Allow time to focus on specific teaching of social and emotional skills.
- Consider providing extra breaks during the course of the school day. Some pupils may need to be redirected to a different activity, have a quick run outside, or regain calm in a quieter area of the school.
- Consider the way that tasks are presented in class. Break down text into smaller chunks and have photocopies of a lesson's objectives and success criteria to help the pupil understand what they need to complete.
- Differentiate tasks to make them achievable, but also sufficiently challenging.
- Allow time for the pupil to [process information](#), such as instructions and questions.
- Refer to the information on the [Education professionals](#) section of the National Autistic Society website. Professionals working in the field of autism can also sign up to [Autism Practice](#) to receive free information and resources.

Listening to autistic young people's experiences of school is vital. By working together, developing an understanding of their needs and providing tailored support, barriers can be overcome and every pupil can be enabled to enjoy school and fulfil their potential.





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Explore our resources and guides for parents:

- Parent Guide for Working Together with Your Child's School

Our Parent Guide gives ideas on questions you might want to ask when choosing a school for your child.

- Top Tips, Strategies and Resources for Parents

A collection of 10 practical strategies and additional tips to support parents of autistic children and young people.

- A guide to help parents navigate equality law, rights and entitlements when their autistic child is excluded or at risk of exclusion from school

This resource outlines the legal duties the Equality Act 2010 places on your child's school in relation to the exclusion of disabled pupils.

Visit www.autismeducationtrust.org.uk to find out more information about our training modules, including the Autism and Inclusion module.

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